



AI



A timeline of the US
semiconductor market in
2025

It's been a tumultuous year for the U.S. semiconductor industry.

The semiconductor industry plays a sizable role in the "AI race" that the U.S. seems determined to win, which is why this context is worth paying attention to: from Intel's appointment of Lip-Bu Tan to CEO — who wasted no time getting to work trying to revitalize the legacy company — to Joe Biden proposing sweeping new AI chip export rules on his way out of office that never came to fruition.

Here's a look at what's happened so far in 2025.

IMAGE CREDITS:

YUICHIRO CHINO / GETTY IMAGES

July

Intel continues to look for efficiency

July 24: Intel announced that it was [pulling back on some of its manufacturing operations](#). The company will no longer pursue its previously announced projects in Germany and Poland and is consolidating its test operations. Intel also announced it plans to end this year with around 75,000 employees.

Trump's AI Action Plan

July 23: The Trump administration unveiled its much-anticipated [AI Action Plan](#) alongside multiple

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related executive orders. While the plan includes a lot regarding the need for U.S. chip export controls, and for the U.S. to coordinate with its allies on this effort, it doesn't provide any concrete information on what these restrictions would look like.

Groundbreaking UAE AI deal reportedly on hold

July 17: The Trump administration helped foster a groundbreaking deal in May that resulted in a commitment from the United Arab Emirates to buy billions of dollars' worth of AI chips from Nvidia. But now [that deal is reportedly on hold](#) as the U.S. works through national security concerns and fears that those chips could be smuggled from the Middle East to China.

Nvidia is a bargaining chip

July 16: A day after semiconductor firms like Nvidia and AMD got the green light to resume selling certain AI chips to China, we found out why. U.S. Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick said the plans to allow U.S. companies to start selling AI chips in China is [tied to ongoing trade discussions](#) between the U.S. and China regarding rare earth elements.

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U.S. chips head back to China

July 14: Nvidia said it was filing an application to [restart sales of H20 AI chips](#) in China, [confirming rumors from a few weeks prior](#). The company also announced that it would be selling a new chip, the RTX Pro, which was designed specifically for the Chinese market.

Malaysia fights chip smuggling

July 14: Malaysia announced that it was launching [trade permits for U.S.-made AI chips](#). Under this new restriction, any individual or business would need to give the Malaysian government 30 days notice before exporting any U.S. AI chips.

June

Intel appoints new leadership

June 18: Intel announced [four new leadership appointments](#) that Intel says will help it move toward its goal of becoming an engineering-first company again. Intel announced a new chief revenue officer in addition to multiple high-profile engineering hires.

Intel to begin layoffs

June 17: Intel will begin to [lay off a significant chunk of its Intel Foundry staff](#) in July. The company plans

to eliminate at least 15%, and up to 20%, of workers in that business unit. These layoffs aren't a shock: It was rumored back in April, and Intel's CEO Lip-Bu Tan has said he wants to flatten the organization.

Nvidia won't report on China

June 13: Nvidia isn't counting on the U.S. backing off of its AI chip export restrictions anytime soon. After the company took a financial hit from the newly imposed licensing requirements on its H20 AI chips, Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang said the company will [no longer include the Chinese market](#) in future revenue and profit forecasts.

AMD acquires the team behind Untether AI

June 6: AMD makes another acquisition — this time focused on talent. The company [acqui-hired the team behind Untether AI](#), which develops AI inference chips, as the semiconductor giant continues to round out its AI offerings.

AMD is coming for Nvidia's AI hardware dominance

June 4: AMD continued its shopping spree. The company [acquired AI software optimization startup Brium](#), which helps companies retrofit AI software to work with different AI hardware. With a lot of AI software being designed with Nvidia hardware in mind, this acquisition isn't surprising.

May

Nvidia lays out the impact of chip export restrictions

May 28: Nvidia reported that U.S. licensing requirements on its H20 AI chips [cost the company \\$4.5 billion in charges](#) during Q1. The company expects these requirements to result in an \$8 billion hit to Nvidia's revenue in Q2.

AMD acquires Enosemi

May 28: AMD kicks off its acquisition spree. The semiconductor company [announced that it acquired Enosemi](#), a silicon photonics startup. Enosemi's tech, which uses light photons to transmit data, is becoming an increasing area of interest for semiconductor companies.

Tensions start to flare between China and the U.S.

May 21: China's Commerce Secretary didn't like the U.S.'s guidance, issued on May 13, that warned U.S. companies that using Huawei's AI chips "anywhere in the world" was a U.S. chip export violation. The commerce secretary [issued a statement that threatened legal action](#) against anyone caught enforcing that export restriction.

Intel may be starting to offload its non-core units

May 20: Intel CEO Lip-Bu Tan seemingly got right to work on his plan to spin out Intel's non-core business units. The semiconductor giant is reportedly looking to [offload its networking and edge units](#), which makes chips for telecom equipment, and was responsible for \$5.4 billion of the company's 2024 revenue.

The Biden administration's AI Diffusion rule is officially dead

May 13: Just days before the Biden administration's Artificial Intelligence Diffusion Rule was set to go into place, the [U.S. Department of Commerce formally rescinded it](#). The DOC said that it plans to issue new guidance in the future, and in the meantime companies should remember that using Huawei's Ascend AI chips anywhere in the world is a violation of U.S. export rules.

A last-minute reversal

May 7: Just a week before the "Framework for Artificial Intelligence Diffusion" was set to go into place, the Trump administration plans on taking a different path. According to multiple media outlets, including [Axios](#) and [Bloomberg](#), the administration won't enforce the restrictions when they were supposed to start on May 15 and is instead working on its own framework.

April

Anthropic doubles down on its support of chip export restrictions

April 30: Anthropic [doubled down on its support](#) for restricting U.S.-made chip exports, including some tweaks to the Framework for Artificial Intelligence Diffusion, like imposing further restrictions on Tier 2 countries and dedicating resources to enforcement. [An Nvidia spokesperson shot back](#), saying, "American firms should focus on innovation and rise to the challenge, rather than tell tall tales that large, heavy, and sensitive electronics are somehow smuggled in 'baby bumps' or 'alongside live lobsters.'"

Planned layoffs at Intel

April 22: Ahead of its Q1 earnings call, Intel said it was planning to lay off more than [21,000 employees](#). The layoffs were meant to streamline management, something CEO Lip-Bu Tan has long said Intel needed to do, and help rebuild the company's engineering focus.

The Trump administration further restricts chip exports

April 15: Nvidia's H20 AI chip got hit with an export [licensing requirement](#), the company disclosed in an SEC filing. The company added it expects \$5.5 billion in charges related to this new requirement in the first quarter of its 2026 fiscal year. The H20 is the most advanced AI chip Nvidia can still export to China in some form or fashion. TSMC and Intel reported similar expenses the same week.

Nvidia appears to talk its way out of further chip exports

April 9: Nvidia's CEO [Jensen Huang was spotted attending dinner at Donald Trump's Mar-a-Lago resort](#), according to reports. At the time, [NPR reported](#) Huang may have been able to spare Nvidia's H20 AI chips from export restrictions upon agreeing to invest in AI data centers in the U.S.

An alleged agreement between Intel and TSMC

April 3: Intel and TSMC [allegedly reached a tentative agreement](#) to launch a joint chipmaking venture. This joint venture would operate Intel's chipmaking facilities, and TSMC would have a 20% stake in the

new venture. Both companies declined to comment or confirm. If this deal doesn't come to fruition, this is likely a decent preview of potential deals in this industry to come.

Intel spins off noncore assets, announces new initiative

April 1: CEO Lip-Bu Tan got to work right away. Just weeks after he joined Intel, the company announced that it was going to [spin off noncore assets](#) so it could focus. He also said the company would launch new products, including custom semiconductors for customers.

March

Intel names a new CEO

March 12: Intel announced that industry veteran, and former board member, [Lip-Bu Tan would return to the company as CEO](#) on March 18. At the time of his appointment, Tan said Intel would be an “engineering-focused company” under his leadership.

February

Intel's Ohio chip plant gets delayed again

February 28: Intel was supposed to start operating its first chip fabrication plant in Ohio this year. Instead, [the company slowed down construction](#) on the plant for the second time in February. Now the \$28 billion semiconductor project won't wrap up construction until 2030 and may not even open until 2031.

Senators call for more chip export restrictions

February 3: U.S. senators, including Elizabeth Warren (D-Mass) and Josh Hawley (R-Mo), wrote a letter to Commerce Secretary Nominee-Designate Howard Lutnick [urging the Trump administration to further restrict](#) AI chip exports. The letter specifically referred to Nvidia's H20 AI chips, which were used in the training of DeepSeek's R1 "reasoning" model.

January

DeepSeek releases its open "reasoning" model

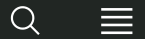
January 27: Chinese AI startup [DeepSeek](#) caused quite the stir in Silicon Valley when it released the [open version of its R1 "reasoning" model](#). While this isn't semiconductor news specifically, the sheer alarm in the AI and semiconductor industries DeepSeek's release caused continues to have ripple effects on the chip industry.

Joe Biden's executive order on chip exports

January 13: With just a week left in office, former president Joe Biden [proposed sweeping new export restrictions](#) on U.S.-made AI chips. This order created a three-tier structure that determined how many U.S. chips can be exported to each country. Under this proposal, Tier 1 countries faced no restrictions; Tier 2 countries had a chip purchase limit for the first time; and Tier 3 countries got additional restrictions.

Anthropic's Dario Amodei weighs in on chip export restrictions

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Nvidia expects to lose billions in revenue due to H20 chip licensing requirements

Rebecca Szkutak — 2:03 PM PDT · May 28, 2025

As Nvidia reports earnings for the first quarter of its fiscal year 2026, which closed on April 28, the company has released numbers on how the Trump administration's recent chip-export restrictions are affecting business.

Nvidia [reported that it incurred a \\$4.5 billion charge](#) in Q1 due to licensing requirements impacting its ability to sell its H20 AI chip to companies in China. The chipmaker also reported that it was unable to ship an additional \$2.5 billion of H20 revenue in the quarter due to the restrictions.

When the U.S. licensing requirement was originally announced in April, the company [said that it expected \\$5.5 billion in related charges](#) for Q1.

Nvidia also said Wednesday that the H20 licensing requirements will result in an \$8 billion hit to the

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company's revenue in Q2, which is predicted to be around \$45 billion — a significant toll.

In the company's Q1 earnings call, CEO Jensen Huang said that the company is currently exploring ways to still compete in China's AI market but that, for now, it has to take a write-off for its H2O chips.

"China is one of the world's largest AI markets and a springboard to global success with half of the world's AI researchers based there; the platform that wins China is positioned to lead globally today," Huang said. "However, the \$50 billion China market is effectively closed to us. The H2O export ban ended our Hopper data center business in China. We cannot reduce Hopper further to comply."

The [company has been outspoken](#) against the Trump administration's push to limit the export of U.S.-made AI chips to countries, including China. [Huang praised](#) the [administration's recent decision to scrap Joe Biden's Artificial Intelligence Diffusion Rule](#) that would have imposed further chip-export restrictions.

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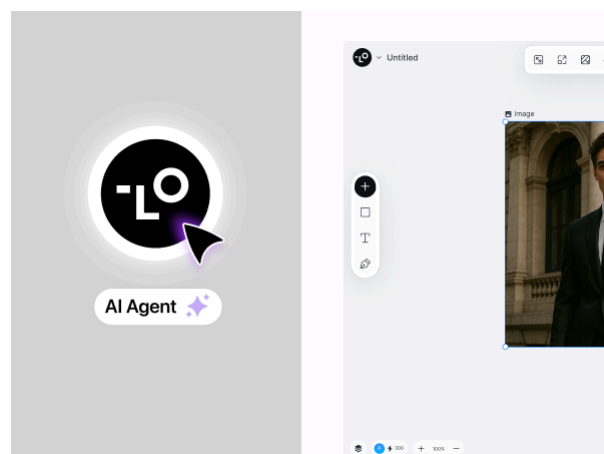
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Despite [Biden's chip-export rules not coming to bear](#), Nvidia is clearly not immune to the Trump administration's attempt to stifle China's AI market.

"The question is not whether China will have AI; it already does," Huang said. "The question is whether one of the world's largest AI markets will run on American platforms. Shielding Chinese chip makers from U.S. competition only strengthens them abroad and weakens America's position."

This piece has been updated to include commentary from Nvidia's earnings call.

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Nvidia's resumption of H20 chip sales related to rare-earth element trade talks

Rebecca Szkutak — 9:57 AM PDT · July 16, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: LI HONGBO/VCG / GETTY IMAGES

Rare-earth elements appear to be behind Nvidia's stance on China.

After announcing in June plans to essentially [withdraw from the Chinese market](#), the semiconductor chip and AI giant reversed course and said it was filing an application to [restart sales of its H20 AI chip to China](#).

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U.S. Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick said Tuesday that Nvidia's plans to start selling its H20 AI chips are tied to ongoing trade discussions with



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China regarding rare-earth elements, [according to reporting from Reuters](#). [AMD plans to restart sales of its MI308 AI chip](#) in China too.

Rare-earth elements (REE) like lanthanum and cerium, which are largely mined in China, are necessary components in technology, including rechargeable batteries for electric vehicles. These REEs have become a critical point in the current trade debates between the U.S. and China.

Not everyone is happy with this trade development though.

The decision “would not only hand our foreign adversaries our most advanced technologies, but is also dangerously inconsistent with this administration’s previously-stated position on export controls for China,” Congressman Raja Krishnamoorthi said in a statement, according to Reuters.

But Lutnick isn’t concerned and told CNBC on Tuesday that China is only getting [Nvidia’s “fourth best” chip](#).

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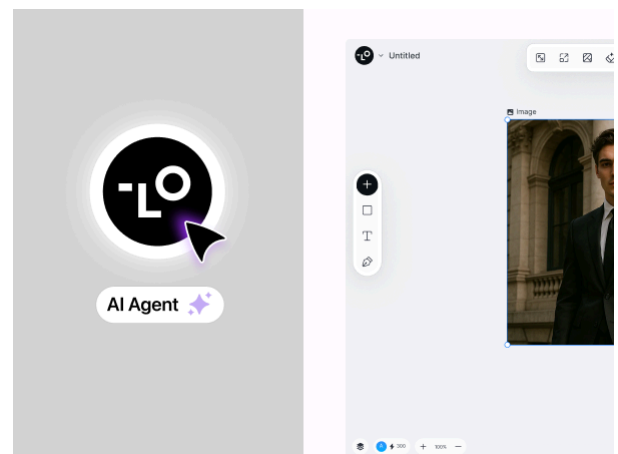
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“We don’t sell them our best stuff, not our second best stuff, not even our third best,” Lutnick said in the interview.

This news comes less than a week after it was rumored that Nvidia would be [designing and releasing a new AI chip specifically for the Chinese market](#) to resume business in the country without violating U.S. chip export rules.

The U.S. is still trying to figure out what its AI chip export rules are going to look like. The Trump administration [formally rescinded the Biden administration’s AI Diffusion Rule](#) in May and there hasn’t been a formal update since.

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The Trump administration was [rumored to be considering further restrictions on AI chip exports to countries like Thailand and Malaysia](#), to prevent smuggling, Bloomberg reported last week. Malaysia [implemented trade permits on U.S.-made AI chips](#) on Monday.

TechCrunch reached out to Nvidia for comment.

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